

What else to watch: *Strike* (1925) ■ *October* (1928) ■ *Man With a Movie Camera* (1929) ■ *The Untouchables* (1987) ■ *JFK* (1991)

A carriage careers down the steps past and over the bodies of the dead and dying. The baby's mother has been shot: as she fell, she nudged it forward, starting its headlong descent.

Odessa Steps. Now known as the Potemkin Stairs, they were then just the Boulevard Steps, or Giant Staircase. The director made full use of the 200 steps to show the tsarist troops advancing. The crowds' celebration with the sailors is cut short by a title card that says simply, "And suddenly." The scenes of carnage that follow have lost none of their power. Nobody is safe from the advancing troops, filmed from a low angle and often tightly cropped: for the director, only their rifles needed to be visible. The outraged sailors fire back with shells, before heading off to sea where they are joined in revolt by other sailors.

Montage and collision

As a history lesson, *Battleship Potemkin* took liberties, but factual accuracy was never Eisenstein's concern. It was more important for him to pursue a new cinematic language, which he did by drawing



on the experiments in montage pioneered by Soviet movie theorist Lev Kuleshov between 1910 and 1920. For Kuleshov, meaning lay not in individual shots but in the way that the human mind contextualizes them: for example, by using the same image of a man's face and intercutting it with a bowl of soup, a coffin, and a woman, Kuleshov could conjure up images of hunger,

grief, and desire. Eisenstein's belief in montage—although he preferred to use images in "collision" with each other—can be shown by statistics alone: at under 80 minutes, *Battleship Potemkin* consists of 1,346 shots, when the average movie of the period usually contained around 600.

Manipulating emotions

Eisenstein's approach to storytelling still seems radical today. Its juxtaposition of the epic and the intimate virtually rules out the possibility of engaging with the characters on a personal level, and in that way it is indeed perfectly communist. Even Vakulinchuk, the hero and martyr of the piece, is seen only as a symbol of humanity to be contrasted with the faceless tsarist troops. The most famous scene—a baby in a carriage tumbling down the steps—is the ideal symbol of the movie's manipulative grip on our helpless emotions. ■



Sergei Eisenstein Director

Born in 1898 in Latvia, Sergei Eisenstein started work as

a director for theater company Proletkult in Moscow in 1920. His interest in visual theory led to the "Revolution Trilogy" of *Strike*, *Battleship Potemkin*, and *October*. He was invited to Hollywood in 1930, but his projects there stalled. Back in

the Soviet Union, he found that the political tide had turned against his "formalist" ideas, to more traditional storytelling. He died in 1948, leaving behind just eight finished movies.

Key movies

1925 *Battleship Potemkin*
1928 *October*
1938 *Alexander Nevsky*